

HVIA DATA & AI SOLUTIONS

Historical Company Research

Olist: Brazilian E-Commerce Public Dataset

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Subject Company	Olist, Brazilian E-Commerce Platform
Research Focus	Olist business context relevant to the dataset period (2016-2018)
Report Type	Historical Business Research

This report establishes the historical business context for Olist ahead of the quantitative analysis of the accompanying e-commerce dataset.

1. Research Agenda

Before diving into the Olist dataset, this research first lays out the company's historical business context. The goal is straightforward: understand who Olist served, what problems it solved, how it created value, and how all of this ties back to the data available.

01 Dataset & Historical Context

Identify the relevant dataset period and align the company research with it.

02 Historical Company Research

Study Olist using sources relevant to the historical business context.

03 Source-by-Source Extraction

Answer the same business questions using only evidence supported by each source.

04 Business Model Consolidation

Combine evidence across sources into one structured historical view.

05 Dataset Connection

Map the business model to the tables and business activities represented in the dataset.

2. Historical Research Method

This research takes a historical lens rather than a present-day one. Instead of describing Olist as it operates today, the focus stays on the business context that matches the period covered by the dataset. Each source is reviewed on its own terms, and information only makes it into the findings when that specific source actually supports it.

3. Questions We Answer From Every Source

The same set of questions is applied to every article or historical source reviewed. When a source does not offer enough evidence to answer a question, that gap is recorded as “Not specified in this source” rather than filled in with a guess.

1. Who were Olist's target customers?
2. What problem was Olist solving for these customers?
3. Why did these customers need Olist?
4. How did Olist create value for its customers?
5. What products, services, or capabilities did Olist provide?
6. How did Olist connect sellers with marketplaces and consumers?
7. What role did logistics and fulfillment play?
8. What role did payments, inventory, pricing, and order management play?
9. How did Olist use data, dashboards, or analytics?
10. Who were the main actors in Olist's business ecosystem?

11. What evidence does the source provide about Olist's business model?
12. What evidence does the source provide about Olist's business impact or strategic position?
13. What important information is not specified by this source?

4. Historical Source Framework

The dataset represents Olist activity from approximately 2016 to 2018, so the primary company research needs to reflect that same window. The SME Business Review profile used earlier in this report is a 2025 publication — useful for current context, but not a contemporaneous account of the 2016–2018 business model. It has been kept, relabeled as a supplementary current source, and moved later in the report.

Because the dataset represents the 2016–2018 period, contemporaneous sources from 2017–2018 are used as the primary evidence for reconstructing Olist's historical business model. The 2025 SME Business Review article is retained only as supplementary current context.

Four contemporaneous sources, published between May 2017 and June 2018, are analyzed below using the same 13 research questions applied earlier in this report.

5. Historical Source 1: Tiago Dalvi — Medium (2017)

Title	The Customer Relationship Revolution at Olist
Author	Tiago Dalvi
Date	3 May 2017
Source	Medium
Source Type	Founder / first-person business article
Historical Relevance	Direct, first-person description of Olist's business model and operations during the dataset period.
Link	https://medium.com/@tiago_dalvi/a-revolu%C3%A7%C3%A3o-na-%C3%A1rea-de-relacionamento-com-o-cliente-no-olist-b9a764da2f68

Key Evidence Extracted

- Olist served **micro, small and medium-sized merchants**.
- It also worked with distributors, importers, manufacturers, and retailers.
- Olist had commercial relationships with major marketplaces.
- The company consolidated product, inventory, order, delivery, customer service, and payment activities.
- The source describes the model as a **hybrid between SaaS and Marketplace**.

- Revenue was described as recurring subscription revenue plus commission on sales.
- Olist interacted with marketplaces, merchants, and final consumers.
- The source discusses metrics, dashboards, queries, and operational analysis.

Answers to the Research Questions

1. Target Customers

Micro, small, and medium-sized merchants are named directly, alongside distributors, importers, manufacturers, and retailers that Olist also worked with.

2. Business Problem

Not specified in this source. The article centers on how Olist's customer-relationship function evolved rather than on the specific obstacles merchants faced.

3. Why They Needed Olist

Not specified in this source.

4. Value Created

By consolidating product, inventory, order, delivery, customer service, and payment activities into a single operation, Olist reduced the number of separate functions merchants had to manage themselves.

5. Products / Services

The source points to a consolidated set of capabilities spanning product, inventory, order, delivery, customer service, and payment activities, rather than listing discrete named products.

6. Marketplace / Consumer Access

Olist is described as holding commercial relationships with major marketplaces, positioning it between merchants and these platforms.

7. Logistics / Fulfillment

Not specified in this source.

8. Payments / Inventory / Pricing / Orders

Order, delivery, and payment activities are named as part of the operations Olist consolidated on merchants' behalf; specific pricing mechanics are not discussed.

9. Data / Analytics

The source explicitly discusses metrics, dashboards, queries, and operational analysis, reflecting a data-driven approach to running the customer-relationship function.

10. Ecosystem Actors

Marketplaces, merchants, and final consumers are identified as the parties Olist interacted with.

11. Business Model

The source explicitly frames Olist's model as a hybrid between SaaS and Marketplace, with revenue coming from recurring subscription fees plus commission on sales.

12. Business Impact / Strategic Position

Not specified in this source.

13. Information Not Specified

This first-person account does not detail the specific problems merchants faced, logistics operations, or pricing structures; it focuses mainly on the customer-relationship function and the underlying business-model type.

6. Historical Source 2: Mercado&Consumo (2017)

Title	Startup helps small retailers sell products on marketplaces.
Publisher	Mercado&Consumo
Date	26 June 2017
Source Type	Business / retail news
Historical Relevance	Contemporaneous description of Olist's customers, marketplace relationships, pricing, and operating model.
Link	https://mercadoeconsumo.com.br/26/06/2017/noticias/startup-ajuda-pequenos-lojistas-a-vender-produtos-em-marketplaces/

Key Evidence Extracted

- Olist connected entrepreneurs wanting to sell online with large e-commerce businesses.
- Small retailers were Olist's customers.
- Products were exposed through large partner e-commerce sites.
- Partners named include **Mercado Livre, Walmart, B2W, and Via Varejo**.
- Olist provided order-management functionality.
- Olist transferred product payments to entrepreneurs.
- The source reports subscription pricing plus a **20% commission** on product sales.
- Olist screened merchants for quality, legal compliance, and delivery performance.
- The article reports about **2,100 small retailers** connected at the time, with a stated target of **4,000 partners**.

Answers to the Research Questions

1. Target Customers

Small retailers and entrepreneurs looking to sell online are identified as Olist's customers.

2. Business Problem

Entrepreneurs wanting to sell online lacked a direct route into large e-commerce businesses on their own.

3. Why They Needed Olist

Negotiating individually with large marketplaces was impractical for small retailers, which made Olist's intermediation valuable.

4. Value Created

Olist connected entrepreneurs to large e-commerce businesses, exposing their products on major partner sites without each retailer negotiating its own marketplace relationships, while screening merchants for quality, legal compliance, and delivery performance.

5. Products / Services

Order-management functionality and payment transfers to entrepreneurs are described as core parts of the service, alongside product exposure on partner marketplaces.

6. Marketplace / Consumer Access

Products were listed and exposed through large partner e-commerce sites, explicitly naming Mercado Livre, Walmart, B2W, and Via Varejo as partners.

7. Logistics / Fulfillment

Not specified in this source beyond Olist's screening of merchants for delivery performance.

8. Payments / Inventory / Pricing / Orders

Olist managed order processing and transferred product payments to entrepreneurs; pricing followed a subscription model plus a reported 20% commission on product sales.

9. Data / Analytics

Not specified in this source.

10. Ecosystem Actors

Entrepreneurs and small retailers, large e-commerce partners (Mercado Livre, Walmart, B2W, Via Varejo), and Olist as the intermediary make up the ecosystem described.

11. Business Model

The source reports a subscription fee combined with a 20% commission on product sales as Olist's revenue model.

12. Business Impact / Strategic Position

At the time of publication, around 2,100 small retailers were connected through Olist, with a stated target of reaching 4,000 partners, pointing to an active growth phase.

13. Information Not Specified

The source does not detail Olist's data or analytics capabilities, nor its logistics operations beyond merchant screening for delivery performance.

7. Historical Source 3: Gazeta do Povo (2017)

Title	Olist aims to become the largest online store within marketplaces.
Publisher	Gazeta do Povo
Date	14 November 2017
Source Type	Business / technology news
Historical Relevance	Contemporaneous description of Olist's scale, marketplace relationships, pricing, and operating model.
Link	https://www.gazetadopovo.com.br/economia/nova-economia/olist-quer-ser-a-maior-loja-virtual-dentro-dos-principais-marketplaces-do-pais-3xbe9k4mn13uzs1pm60ym6znz/

Key Evidence Extracted

- Olist had around **2,300 partner merchants** and roughly **130,000 products** listed.
- Olist operated inside **Mercado Livre, Walmart, B2W, Via Varejo, and Amazon**.
- Small retailers could work with Olist instead of negotiating separately with each marketplace.
- Olist published and sold merchants' products through the marketplaces.
- Sellers themselves prepared products for shipment.
- Olist had a **Correios** (Brazilian postal service) partnership.
- The source reports an annual subscription plus a **20% commission** on the final order price, including freight.
- Many partner merchants were primarily offline retailers using Olist to sell online.
- Olist aimed to become the largest virtual store operating within the main marketplaces.

Answers to the Research Questions

1. Target Customers

Small retailers, many of them primarily offline businesses, are identified as Olist's partner merchants, using the platform to expand into e-commerce.

2. Business Problem

Negotiating individually with each major marketplace was presented as a barrier facing small retailers.

3. Why They Needed Olist

Working through Olist let retailers avoid separate negotiations with each marketplace, gaining shared access to several platforms at once.

4. Value Created

Olist published and sold merchants' products across several major marketplaces on their behalf, letting primarily offline retailers reach online consumers without managing each marketplace relationship directly.

5. Products / Services

The source describes product publishing and sales management across marketplaces, plus a logistics partnership with Correios; sellers remained responsible for preparing products for shipment.

6. Marketplace / Consumer Access

At the time of publication, Olist operated inside Mercado Livre, Walmart, B2W, Via Varejo, and Amazon, with around 2,300 partner merchants and roughly 130,000 products listed.

7. Logistics / Fulfillment

Olist maintained a partnership with Correios, while sellers were responsible for preparing their own products for shipment.

8. Payments / Inventory / Pricing / Orders

Pricing followed an annual subscription plus a 20% commission calculated on the final order price, including freight.

9. Data / Analytics

Not specified in this source.

10. Ecosystem Actors

Partner merchants (largely offline retailers), major marketplaces (Mercado Livre, Walmart, B2W, Via Varejo, Amazon), Correios as a logistics partner, and Olist as the intermediary make up the ecosystem described.

11. Business Model

The source reports an annual subscription combined with a 20% commission on the final order price including freight.

12. Business Impact / Strategic Position

Olist is described as aiming to become the largest virtual store operating within the main marketplaces, reflecting a strategy built on scale across partner platforms rather than a standalone storefront.

13. Information Not Specified

The source does not discuss Olist's data or analytics tools, nor its customer-service operations.

8. Historical Source 4: PEGN / Endeavor Brasil (2018)

Title	Tiago Dalvi, da Olist: “Nenhum modelo de negócio está escrito em pedra”
Publisher	Pequenas Empresas Grandes Negócios / Endeavor Brasil
Date	15 June 2018
Source Type	Founder story / business profile
Historical Relevance	Explains the historical transition from Solidarium to Olist and why the marketplace-enablement model was chosen.
Link	https://revistapegn.globo.com/Banco-de-ideias/E-commerce/noticia/2018/06/tiago-dalvi-da-olist-nenhum-modelo-de-negocio-esta-escrito-em-pedra.html

Key Evidence Extracted

- The company started from the problem of helping people with good products reach consumers.
- The physical retail model was difficult to scale against large retailers.
- The company studied online marketplace models such as **eBay and Etsy**.
- The strategy shifted toward integrating the supplier network with existing marketplaces.
- Olist chose to leverage existing marketplace reach instead of directly competing with large retailers.
- Olist was described as a large department store made up of small stores.
- A single registration could let merchants place products in several retailers without the same level of bureaucracy.

Answers to the Research Questions

1. Target Customers

Not specified with the same granularity as the other sources; the article speaks broadly of suppliers and merchants with good products who struggled to reach consumers, later connected to several retailers through a single registration.

2. Business Problem

The founding problem was helping people with good products reach consumers, at a time when a physical retail model was difficult to scale against large retailers.

3. Why They Needed Olist

Competing directly against large retailers through physical retail was impractical; studying marketplace models such as eBay and Etsy pointed toward integrating suppliers with marketplaces that already commanded consumer reach.

4. Value Created

A single registration through Olist let merchants place products across several retailers without the bureaucracy of registering with each one separately.

5. Products / Services

The source describes this single-registration mechanism for reaching multiple retailers, rather than listing individual product features.

6. Marketplace / Consumer Access

Olist integrated its supplier network with existing marketplaces rather than building a standalone consumer-facing store, described in the source as a large department store made up of many small stores.

7. Logistics / Fulfillment

Not specified in this source.

8. Payments / Inventory / Pricing / Orders

Not specified in this source.

9. Data / Analytics

Not specified in this source.

10. Ecosystem Actors

Suppliers and merchants, and existing online marketplaces, are the actors described, with Olist acting as the integration layer between them.

11. Business Model

The source frames the business model as one built on leveraging established marketplace reach rather than direct competition, evolving from an earlier, harder-to-scale physical-retail approach; it does not restate pricing or commission details.

12. Business Impact / Strategic Position

The founder describes the shift from physical retail toward marketplace integration as a deliberate strategic pivot, explicitly stating that no business model is fixed in stone.

13. Information Not Specified

The source does not cover pricing, commission, logistics, or data and analytics; it focuses on the strategic and historical reasoning behind the business model.

9. Cross-Source Validation

This section does not restate each source's answers. Instead, it checks which findings recur across more than one contemporaneous source, which strengthens confidence in that finding, and flags anything that currently rests on a single source.

Business Dimension	Historical Finding	Supporting Sources
Target Customers	Small, micro, and medium-sized retailers and professional merchants.	Dalvi 2017; Mercado&Consumo 2017; Gazeta do Povo 2017; PEGN 2018
Core Problem	Difficulty accessing and operating across online marketplaces individually.	Mercado&Consumo 2017; Gazeta do Povo 2017; PEGN 2018
Core Value	Simplifying marketplace access and reducing operational complexity for merchants.	Dalvi 2017; Mercado&Consumo 2017; Gazeta do Povo 2017; PEGN 2018
Marketplace Role	Olist acted as an intermediary / integration layer between merchants and major marketplaces.	Dalvi 2017; Mercado&Consumo 2017; Gazeta do Povo 2017; PEGN 2018
Revenue Model	Subscription revenue plus a sales commission.	Dalvi 2017; Mercado&Consumo 2017; Gazeta do Povo 2017
Commission	20% commission is explicitly reported by two 2017 sources.	Mercado&Consumo 2017; Gazeta do Povo 2017
Data & Analytics	Metrics, dashboards, and operational analysis are described, but only in one source.	Dalvi 2017 only — source-specific, not independently confirmed
Logistics	Supported historically, but operational depth differs by source (merchant screening vs. a named carrier partnership).	Mercado&Consumo 2017; Gazeta do Povo 2017
Strategic Position	Olist sought scale by leveraging established marketplaces rather than competing directly with them.	Gazeta do Povo 2017; PEGN 2018

10. Consolidated Historical Olist Business Model

The subsections below synthesize the four contemporaneous sources into one structured view of Olist's 2016–2018 business model, rather than repeating any single article.

Target Customers

Micro, small, and medium-sized retailers and professional sellers, including offline businesses seeking to expand into e-commerce.

Customer Problem

Small sellers faced barriers related to marketplace onboarding, integrations, product and order management, delivery, customer service, and access to consumers at scale.

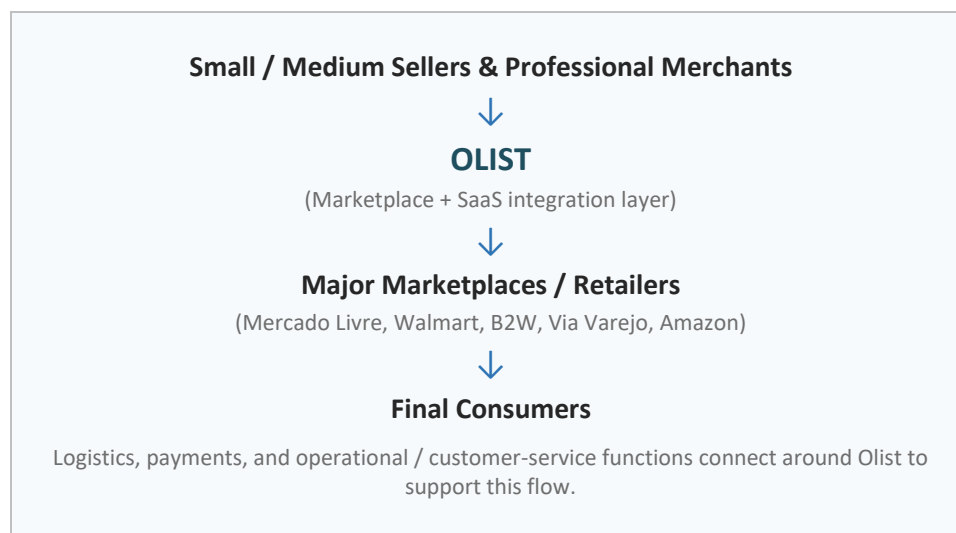
Value Proposition

Olist reduced operational complexity by acting as a single layer connecting merchants with major marketplaces and helping manage important parts of the online-selling process.

Business Model

Historical 2017 sources describe Olist as a hybrid SaaS-and-Marketplace model. Revenue included recurring subscription revenue and a variable commission on sales. Two contemporaneous 2017 sources explicitly report a 20% commission; this rate should not be assumed to apply to every period or every transaction beyond what those sources support.

Ecosystem



Operational Pillars

- Marketplace integration
- Product / catalog management

- Inventory
- Orders
- Payments
- Delivery / logistics
- Customer service
- Operational metrics and analytics

Historical Strategic Position

Olist's historical strategy was to leverage the reach of established marketplaces rather than directly compete with large retailers for the same consumer-acquisition infrastructure, positioning itself as the integration layer between many small sellers and a handful of major sales channels.

11. Historical Business Model → Dataset Mapping

This mapping is our analytical bridge between the historical business research and the dataset structure. It is not presented as a direct statement from the company sources.

Business Area	Dataset Table	What the Data Can Help Investigate
Small merchants / sellers	olist_sellers_dataset	Seller distribution and seller activity
Customers	olist_customers_dataset	Customer / order behavior and geography
Orders	olist_orders_dataset	Order lifecycle and delivery performance
Products	olist_products_dataset	Product categories and characteristics
Order Items	olist_order_items_dataset	Product-level sales and seller activity
Payments	olist_order_payments_dataset	Payment methods, values, installments
Reviews	olist_order_reviews_dataset	Customer satisfaction signals
Geolocation	olist_geolocation_dataset	Geographic patterns
Category Translation	product_category_name_translation	Readable product-category analysis

12. Research Limitations

- The historical sources do not provide a complete financial statement or unit-economics model.
- The 20% commission is explicitly reported by two 2017 sources, but the dataset itself does not contain a direct commission field.
- Capabilities described by later sources should not automatically be projected backward into 2016–2018.
- The 2025 SME Business Review article is supplementary current context, not primary historical evidence.
- Historical research establishes business context; it does not replace quantitative analysis of the dataset.

13. Supplementary Current Source — SME Business Review

This source provides useful current context about Olist's broader platform capabilities, but because it was published in 2025, it is not used as primary evidence for reconstructing the 2016–2018 historical business model.

Article	Olist Helps Small Businesses Sell Online and Compete on Equal Terms
Publisher	SME Business Review
Source Type	Business profile article
Main Focus	Olist, small-business e-commerce enablement, and Tiago Dalvi
Source Link	https://smebusinessreview.com/public/index.php/profiles/profile/olist-small-businesses-sell-online-compete-equal-terms-tiago-dalvi-founder-ceo

Answers to the Research Questions

1. Target Customers

Small businesses, independent sellers, and merchants come across as Olist's core users in this article, typically running with limited staff, limited technical know-how, and limited resources overall.

2. Business Problem

Merchants struggled to reach customers beyond their local area, juggle several marketplaces at once, coordinate deliveries and returns, and get their hands on reliable business data.

3. Why They Needed Olist

Small merchants simply did not have the tools or infrastructure to scale online on their own. Handling listings, inventory, pricing, deliveries, returns, payments, and several marketplaces at once was complex and ate up resources they could not spare.

4. Value Created

The article frames Olist as a bridge into the wider digital economy, bringing marketplace access, inventory and pricing management, shipping support, sales tracking, payments, logistics, and analytics together under one roof.

5. Products and Services

Its offering spans marketplace integration, inventory and pricing synchronization, shipping partnerships, fulfillment, returns management, Olist Shops, payment infrastructure, customer support, dashboards, and reporting.

6. Marketplace and Consumer Access

Merchants build product listings once through Olist and push them out across marketplaces such as Mercado Livre, Amazon, and Americanas, giving sellers reach far beyond their local markets.

7. Logistics and Fulfillment

Logistics stands out as one of the biggest barriers small businesses face, and Olist tackles it through logistics partnerships and an integrated fulfillment network, including Olist Fulfillment and a set of strategically placed distribution centers.

8. Payments, Inventory, Pricing, and Orders

Centralized inventory and pricing management, payment processing, and order-related operations all fall under Olist's infrastructure, according to the article.

9. Data and Analytics

Merchants get dashboards and reports that let them track sales by marketplace, spot fast-moving products, and catch issues before they start hurting revenue.

10. Ecosystem Actors

Merchants, online marketplaces, logistics providers, customers, and service providers all show up as participants in this broader ecosystem.

11. Business Model Evidence

Overall, Olist comes across as an integrated platform that lowers the operational and technical barriers small businesses face, combining marketplace access, logistics support, payment infrastructure, brand-building tools, and data-driven insights in one place.

12. Business Impact / Strategic Position

Merchants who once depended mainly on local foot traffic were able to sell across Brazil, and even internationally, through the marketplaces connected to Olist. The article positions Olist's mission around supporting small businesses and helping them compete with larger retailers.

13. Information Not Specified

This source does not go deep enough to pin down a precise historical revenue model, pricing structure, commission rate, or financial performance; these points will need backing from additional historical sources.

Key Evidence Extracted

- Olist was launched in Curitiba, Brazil, in 2015.
- Small businesses struggled to reach customers beyond their own neighborhoods.
- Olist acted as a bridge connecting merchants to the wider digital economy.
- The platform supports marketplace listings, inventory, pricing, shipping, and sales tracking.
- The article mentions **Mercado Livre, Amazon, and Americanas** by name.
- Olist's logistics offering includes partnerships, fulfillment, distribution centers, and returns management.
- **Olist Shops** provides branded online stores while using Olist's infrastructure.
- Olist provides dashboards and reports for sales and product performance analysis.
- The broader ecosystem also includes financial and business-support services.

Connection Between This Source and the Dataset

The table below maps the business activities discussed in this supplementary source to the Olist dataset. As with the historical mapping above, this is our own analytical interpretation, not a direct statement from the article.

Business Area	Relevant Dataset Table	Potential Analysis
Small merchants / sellers	Sellers	Seller distribution and seller-level analysis
Online customers	Customers	Customer-level order behavior
Orders and sales	Orders + Order Items	Order volume, sales, product and seller activity
Products	Products + Order Items	Product and category performance
Payments	Order Payments	Payment methods, installments, payment values
Delivery / logistics	Orders	Purchase, delivery, and estimated-delivery timestamps
Customer experience	Order Reviews	Review scores and review-related behavior

Supplementary Source Conclusion

Taken together, this source gives a current, business-level picture of Olist's platform capabilities. Because it post-dates the dataset period, it supports general orientation rather than the 2016–2018 business-model reconstruction, which relies on the four contemporaneous sources analyzed earlier.

14. Historical Research Conclusion

The historical research is now sufficient to establish a working business context for the dataset. Across contemporaneous sources, Olist is consistently described as a platform serving smaller merchants by simplifying access to major online marketplaces and centralizing important parts of the online selling process. The historical sources also support a subscription-and-commission model and identify merchants, marketplaces, logistics or postal partners, and consumers as key ecosystem participants.

This business context provides the foundation for the next stage: inspecting the actual Olist dataset and verifying which business activities, relationships, and measurable signals are represented in the available tables.

Next Stage: Dataset Understanding

1. Load all CSV files
2. Inventory tables and columns
3. Understand primary and foreign keys
4. Map table relationships
5. Check missing values and duplicates
6. Check data types and date ranges
7. Understand the order lifecycle
8. Build the data dictionary
9. Identify measurable business signals

15. Sources

1. Tiago Dalvi — Medium, 3 May 2017 https://medium.com/@tiago_dalvi/a-revolu%C3%A7%C3%A3o-na-%C3%A1rea-de-relacionamento-com-o-cliente-no-olist-b9a764da2f68
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3. Gazeta do Povo, 14 November 2017 <https://www.gazetadopovo.com.br/economia/nova-economia/olist-quer-ser-a-maior-loja-virtual-dentro-dos-principais-marketplaces-do-pais-3xbe9k4mn13uzs1pm60ym6znz/>
4. Pequenas Empresas Grandes Negócios / Endeavor Brasil, 15 June 2018 <https://revistapegn.globo.com/Banco-de-ideias/E-commerce/noticia/2018/06/tiago-dalvi-da-olist-nenhum-modelo-de-negocio-esta-escrito-em-pedra.html>
5. Supplementary current source — SME Business Review, 5 August 2025 <https://smebusinessreview.com/public/index.php/profiles/profile/olist-small-businesses-sell-online-compete-equal-terms-tiago-dalvi-founder-ceo>